MLBBQ Research Workshop

Communicating your research: why discussions matter

Scientific writing is getting harder to read

- A 2017 study which analyzed ~700k abstracts from 100+ biomedical journals found that **readability of scientific literature is declining**, (Flesch Reading Ease scale), finding most harder than typical graduate-level text. *Plavén-Sigray et al. (2017)*

Writing groups and workshops increase output

- Several studies have found that publication rates have increased in **people who wrote in short, regular sessions with others holding them accountable**. *McGrail, Rickard & Jones (2006)*

Abstracts are where readers decide:

- Readers and reviewers **screen papers by title and abstract**, and many journals desk-reject a large share of submissions before peer review. A clear abstract decides whether anyone reads the rest.

What is your favorite aspect of your research?



What is your the main method used in your research?



What data do you work with (modality, dataset, etc.)?



Who should care about your work?



Slow down to think: the lost art of penmanship

Note taking and learning

- Students who took notes on laptops wrote more words but their hand written notes copied the lecture word for word much more often. *Mueller & Oppenheimer (2014)*

Brain activity

- An EEG study of about 36 university students found that **handwriting produced more widespread connectivity** across brain regions than typing. These patterns are linked to memory and encoding. *Van der Weel & Van der Meer (2024)*

Speed:

- Adults typically handwrite at about 13-20 words per minute and type at about 40 words per minute. Because handwriting is slower, people **summarize instead of transcribing**.

Exercise

- Take 10 minutes to write down an abstract of your research project

- Form groups where each person will provide feedback on your abstract
  - https://www.keamk.com/random-team-generator

- We will gather to discuss afterwards

Discussion

- **What is the hardest part about writing for you?**



Discussion

- **What is one word your reader should remember?**





Thank you!